

Recurrent Malignant Melanoma 51 Years after the Diagnosis of Ocular Melanoma

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Ocular melanoma can recur many years after initial diagnosis with distant metastasis to various organs, most commonly the liver. A patient was recently seen at our institution with recurrent melanoma 51 years after being diagnosed with ocular melanoma and enucleation of the left eye. We believe this to be the longest disease-free interval for malignant melanoma ever recorded.

The patient is a 71-year-old Caucasian male who was diagnosed with ocular melanoma of the left eye in 1951 and who had subsequent enucleation of the left eye. Sections from the original lesion are no longer in existence, and therefore were not available for review.

The patient presented to an outside hospital in early 2003 after experiencing a sudden onset of abdominal pain that woke him from sleep. Upon presentation, the patient described the pain as dull, aching, and constant. He experienced nausea, but no vomiting, had no signs of abdominal obstruction, and no weight loss. The patient's past medical history was significant for colon polyps, as well as tobacco and alcohol abuse. The physical examination, including abdominal examination, was within normal limits, except for a glass prosthesis in the left orbit. His labs showed a mildly elevated amylase of 62, but were otherwise within normal limits. A CT scan demonstrated an epigastric mass measuring 7.9×7.1 cm around the region of the pancreatic neck. It was unclear from the CT scan whether or not the mass was arising from the pancreatic neck or the small bowel.

The patient was transferred to our institution where an exploratory laparotomy and excision of a retroperitoneal mass was performed. The mass was cystic with rupture and was adherent to the fourth portion of the duodenum and the first part of the jejunum on the serosal surface between the pancreas and small bowel. A frozen section of the cyst wall was diagnosed as a spindle cell neoplasm. Final pathologic examination demonstrated nests and sheets of spindled to epithelioid cells infil-

trating the serosa with abundant hemorrhage and necrosis. The cells demonstrated marked pleomorphism with large vesicular nuclei and occasional nucleoli (Fig. 1). An abundance of coarsely granular pigment was observed in the cytoplasm of many of the cells, and an iron stain was negative. Immunohistochemistry was strongly positive for HMB-45, moderately reactive with S-100 and c-kit, weakly positive for Melan-A, and negative for CD34, desmin, CD99, cytokeratin AE1/AE3, CD57, and NSE (Fig. 2). These findings were consistent with metastatic malignant melanoma, although a second primary melanoma could not be completely excluded.

The patient's postoperative course was unremarkable. A skin examination performed during follow-up review was negative for any suspicious melanocytic or regressed lesions. The patient is doing well two months following surgery and will continue treatment with a medical oncologist.

Ultra-late recurrence of ocular melanoma has been reported in a few cases, yet this case report represents the longest reported disease-free interval. In their study of patients with cutaneous or ocular melanoma recurring after at least a 10 year disease-free interval, Crowley et al¹ reported 2 cases of ocular

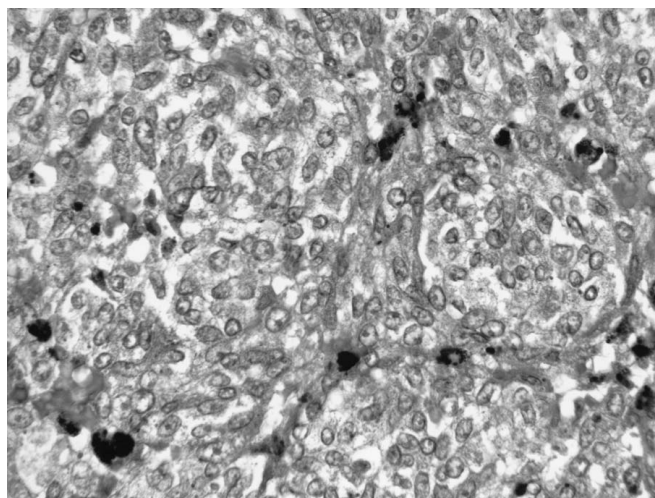


FIGURE 1. Spindled and epithelioid cells with moderate nuclear pleomorphism and occasional prominent nucleoli. Note the vague nested pattern and the scattered melanin pigment deposition (Hematoxylin and eosin).

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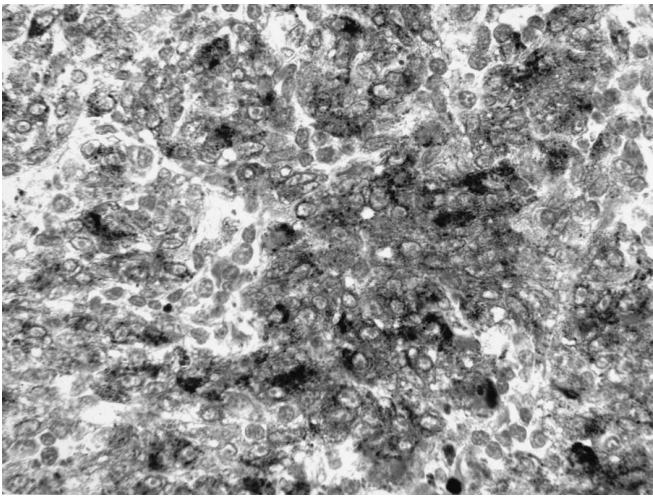


FIGURE 2. An HMB-45 stain demonstrated strong cytoplasmic staining in the nests of tumor cells (HMB-45 stain).

melanoma that recurred after disease-free intervals of 45 and 47 years, which were the 2 longest disease-free intervals described in their study. They found the mean disease-free interval of ocular melanoma to be 22.3 years, versus 14.3 years in

cases of cutaneous melanoma. Furthermore, they reported that patients with ocular melanoma had a higher incidence of distant metastases (92% had distant metastases at the time of recurrence), and a shorter survival time after recurrence than patients with cutaneous melanoma. Ocular melanoma has been associated with a high incidence of liver metastases,² and this was confirmed in the study by Crowley et al, possibly explaining the shorter survival times observed in patients with recurrence from ocular versus cutaneous melanoma.¹

This case illustrates the unpredictable nature of malignant melanoma, especially ocular melanoma. The rate of recurrence with distant metastasis is significant, and can occur after a prolonged disease-free interval. The clinician should remain vigilant in follow-up, being careful to screen patients with diagnoses of melanoma for many decades after initial treatment.

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